

02A / CURRENT PLATFORM VS PROPOSED PLATFORM

Why the current site feels stuck

The current site is not weak because it is written in HTML. HTML is simply the language of web pages. The constraint is the publishing model: each page is a standalone file (attorneys-291.html, practices-55.html). Adding a lawyer or updating a bio means editing a file and republishing. Marketing cannot do that work in-house. That is what a CFO typically hears described as an “HTML platform.”

Robins Kaplan is on Firmseek’s newer content-management generation — records in a system, pages generated from templates. Same category of vendor, different generation. The diagnosis of the old model is fair. The conclusion that only that vendor can fix it is not. The working prototype already makes the same jump for Zelle.

X → Y → what that unlocks

	X · Current site	Y · Proposed site
Live URL	zellelaw.com	zelle-law.vercel.app (working prototype)
What it is	Static HTML files on the current hosting vendor. One file per page.	A modern Next.js application on Vercel, with structured content and a staff administration platform.
Who can change it	A developer or the original vendor. File edit, then republish.	Authorized Zelle staff for routine bios, offices, practices, and listings — without a ticket for every change.
What it looks like	Long static directories. Limited mobile behavior. Dated templates.	Editorial layout, searchable professionals, practice and office pages, insights, and room to add features later.
Who owns it	Tied to the current hosting / publishing vendor.	Zelle owns the source code and approved content. Portable GitHub repository. Not locked to a closed legal-web platform.

ABC · capability the new platform allows

- A. In-house publishing — update professional profiles, offices, practices, and insight listings without waiting on a vendor queue.
- B. A real directory — filter by office and practice instead of a long static attorney list; clean URLs instead of attorneys-291.html.
- C. Modern delivery — mobile-first layout, HTTPS, performance, analytics, redirects, and a controlled DNS cutover. Email and the domain stay in place.
- D. An owned stack — private GitHub repository + Vercel hosting. You can keep Triple I for managed support or take the site to another qualified provider.

How this compares with a Firmseek-style rebuild

Firmseek’s newer work (for example Robins Kaplan) is a CMS-backed law-firm site. That is the right category of upgrade. The difference is ownership and lock-in. Their path keeps you on a proprietary legal-web platform. This proposal moves Zelle off static HTML files onto a site the firm owns — already visible as a working prototype at zelle-law.vercel.app, built from the same starting point as zellelaw.com. Email and Microsoft 365 do not move. Only website hosting changes at cutover.